



ISRAEL*

Capital city: Jerusalem**Area:** 8,109 sq miles
(20,770 sq km)**Population:** 6,400,000**Official languages:**
Hebrew and Arabic**Major religions:** Jewish
80%, Muslim 16%,
Christian 2%, other 2%**Government:** Multi-party
democracy**Currency:** New shekel**Adult literacy rate:** 95%**Life expectancy:** 79 years**People per doctor:** 270**Televisions:** 318 per 1,000
people* Figures include the West Bank
and Gaza Strip.

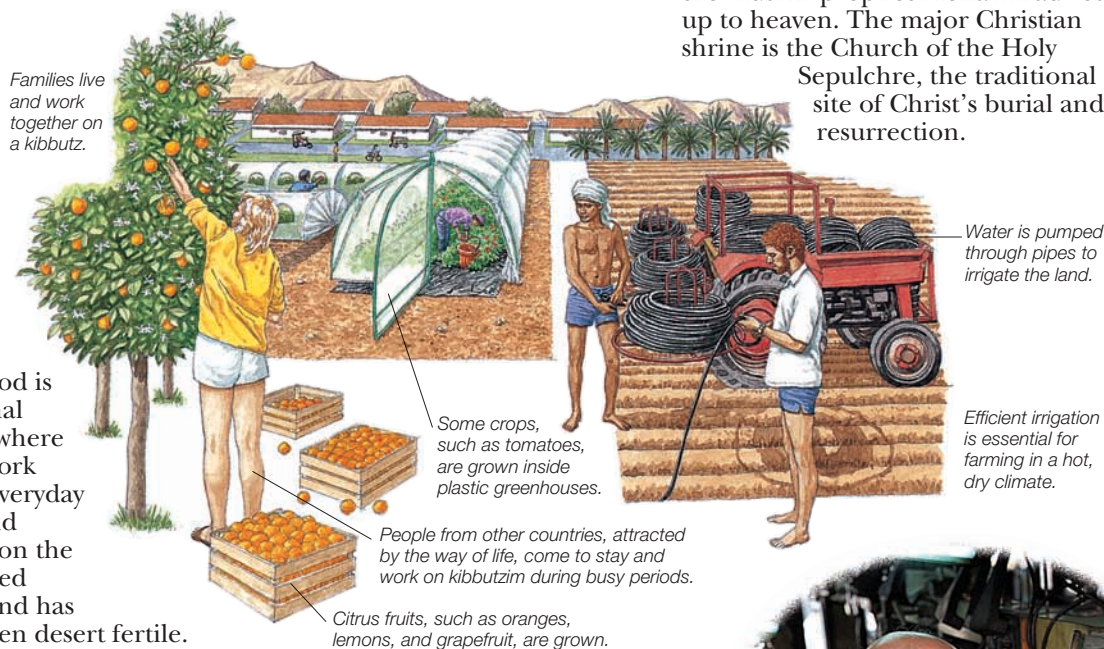
ISRAEL

ISRAEL IS A LONG, THIN STRIP of land running along the eastern coast of the Mediterranean Sea. Its landscape is varied, with fertile valleys, dry deserts, mountains, lakes, and rivers. It has a wide range of industries and a modern agricultural system. The state of Israel was created in 1948 as a homeland for Jews from all over the world. The country was previously called Palestine. Much of the Palestinian Arab population was forced to leave Israel, fleeing into Jordan and Lebanon. This has created conflict between Israel, the Palestinians, and neighboring Arab states ever since.



JERUSALEM

The city of Jerusalem is a holy place for Jews, Muslims, and Christians. Within the walls of the Old City is the Jewish Western Wall, the only remaining part of Herod's Temple, and the Temple Mount, from where the Muslim prophet Mohammad rose up to heaven. The major Christian shrine is the Church of the Holy Sepulchre, the traditional site of Christ's burial and resurrection.



Families live and work together on a kibbutz.

Some crops, such as tomatoes, are grown inside plastic greenhouses.

People from other countries, attracted by the way of life, come to stay and work on kibbutzim during busy periods.

Citrus fruits, such as oranges, lemons, and grapefruit, are grown.

Water is pumped through pipes to irrigate the land.

Efficient irrigation is essential for farming in a hot, dry climate.

KIBBUTZ

Almost half of Israel's food is grown on large communal farms called kibbutzim, where many families live and work together. People share everyday tasks such as cleaning and cooking, as well as work on the farm. Use of computerized irrigation to water the land has made large areas of barren desert fertile.



ISRAELI SOLDIERS

Because of the conflict between Israel and the Palestinians, and repeated wars with neighboring countries, the army plays a crucial part in Israeli life. From the age of 18, Israeli men and women must serve in the army for a number of years. Women receive the same training as men, but do not take part in direct combat.

AT PRAYER

Judaism is one of the world's oldest religions. Jews believe in one God and follow the teachings of the Torah, the first five books of the Bible. At prayer, many Jewish men wear blue-edged prayer shawls and small boxes called phylacteries, or *tephilin*, which contain verses from the Torah. Saturday is the Jewish holy day, or Sabbath.

Tephilin are worn on the head and left arm, near the heart, to show that God's teachings control a person's thoughts and feelings.

Knotted tassels serve to remind Jews of God's commandments.



Prayer shawl



DIAMOND CUTTING

About 25 percent of Israel's export earnings come from its diamond industry. The rough diamonds are imported, and then skillfully cut and polished for use in jewelry settings.

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